

Voice Search and AI Assistants: How Siri, Alexa, and AI Assistants Choose Businesses

2026-09-03 · 7 min read

A voice assistant names one business, maybe two. There is no scrolling through alternatives. For the categories where voice recommendations happen most, earning that mention is a high-stakes visibility challenge.

Quick Answer:

Voice assistants name one or two businesses when asked for a local recommendation, drawing primarily from Google Business Profile data (for Google Assistant and Siri) and business directory data (for Alexa). Earning voice recommendations requires complete GBP, NAP consistency, and strong reviews — with particular weight on review ratings and response speed, since assistants often prioritize the highest-rated, most responsive local option.

When the assistant decides, there is no second result

Desktop search returns a page of results. A voice assistant returns a name. Sometimes two. When someone asks their Google Home, Siri, or Alexa for the best local dentist or accountant, the assistant does not present options — it makes a recommendation. The user either calls the business or they don't.

This compression of choice is what makes voice and assistant AI recommendations so disproportionately valuable. A business that earns voice recommendations in its category and geography will receive a meaningful stream of phone calls from buyers who have already accepted the recommendation.

How different assistants make their recommendations

Google Assistant and Google AI (Gemini) draw primarily from Google's own ecosystem: Google Business Profiles, the Knowledge Graph, and Google's live index. A complete, verified, active GBP with strong review ratings is the most direct path.

Siri primarily uses Yelp data for local business queries in many categories, along with Apple Maps. For Siri visibility, a complete and active Yelp listing with strong ratings is specifically important. Claiming and completing your Apple Maps Connect listing is Siri-specific infrastructure.

Alexa draws from Yelp for many local queries as well. Yelp presence is therefore important for Alexa recommendations too.

ChatGPT voice and similar conversational AI voice interfaces draw on the same signals as their text counterparts, but are particularly likely to pull from well-structured web content and authoritative sources. Schema markup and FAQ-formatted content have higher importance for these interfaces.

The signals that determine voice recommendation selection

Review rating and volume. Voice assistants cannot show a list — they make a single selection. The most reliable selection heuristic across all platforms is review rating. A business with a 4.9 average across 200 reviews will reliably outperform a business with a 4.3 average and 50 reviews.

Category and service specificity. Voice queries tend to be specific: "a plumber who handles emergency pipe repairs." Businesses that have specified their services in detail — in GBP service listings, in Yelp service categories, in structured data — are more likely to match the specific intent of a voice query.

Geographic precision. GBP listing completeness (correct address, verified location pin), service area declarations, and local citation consistency all feed geographic accuracy. A business whose GBP location pin is placed incorrectly will consistently lose voice recommendations to less-qualified competitors.

Response rate and business activity signals. A GBP with recent reviews, recent photos, recent posts, and regular hours updates signals an active business. Assistants appear to prefer active, responsive listings over static ones.

Optimizing specifically for voice query patterns

Voice queries are conversational and often full-sentence: "Who is the best tax attorney near me?" They frequently include question words and action phrases. FAQ-formatted content is the clearest content match for voice query patterns. A FAQ that asks "Who is the best option for [service] in [city]?" and answers with a specific, descriptive response gives assistants a ready-to-use response.

Answer length also matters. Voice responses need to be brief and useful. The first two sentences of any FAQ answer should be usable as a standalone voice response.

What "near me" really means for assistants

Several signals determine whether your business is treated as reliably "near" a given location:

GBP location pin accuracy. The pin must be precisely placed at your actual physical location. A pin that is off by a block is occasionally enough to lose a recommendation.

Service area declarations for non-location businesses. If you serve customers at their location, the Service Area Business setting in GBP is critical. Declare your actual service area, not an aspirational one.

Consistent address data across platforms. Siri uses Apple Maps, which uses address data from multiple sources. Inconsistencies between your GBP address and Apple Maps address can produce absent results for Siri users.

The growing overlap between voice and AI chat

As AI assistants become more sophisticated, the line between voice assistant recommendations and AI chat recommendations is blurring. The signal set you build for AI text recommendations increasingly overlaps with voice recommendations. Voice-specific optimization is not a separate silo — it is an extension of the same entity infrastructure that drives all AI visibility.

Frequently Asked Questions

Q: Which voice assistant should I prioritize for my business?

Prioritize based on your buyer demographics. Google Assistant has the broadest reach and deep Android integration. Siri is dominant on iPhone. Alexa is strong for in-home queries. If uncertain, complete GBP, Yelp, and Apple Maps as a foundation that covers all three.

Q: Does having a phone number that answers quickly affect voice recommendations?

Not directly — assistants don't call your number to test it. However, review content often references response speed, and those reviews influence recommendation scores. A business that fails to answer calls may accumulate negative reviews that lower its rating and reduce recommendation frequency.

Q: Are there specific categories where voice recommendations are more important?

Yes — emergency or time-sensitive categories are particularly voice-heavy: plumbers, locksmiths, emergency medical services, towing, urgent repair services. Restaurants for spontaneous dining decisions are also heavily voice-driven. Professional services are less voice-dominant but still voice-significant.

Q: Does speaking a business name on a smart speaker help train the assistant to recommend it?

Not meaningfully at scale. Personal device history may influence personalized responses for that specific user, but does not affect algorithmic recommendation scores across the user population. Building the authority signals that affect the underlying ranking algorithm is the only reliable path.

Q: My business is in a mall or shared location. Does that affect voice recommendations?

It can, particularly if the location data is ambiguous. Make sure your GBP location pin is precisely placed at your specific entrance or suite. Use suite numbers in your address consistently. If your business name is easily confused with others in the same complex, add descriptive language to your GBP description to aid disambiguation.

Q: Is SpeakableSpecification schema worth implementing?

Yes, particularly if your buyers are likely to use AI voice interfaces like ChatGPT voice or Google AI. SpeakableSpecification marks specific content sections as suitable for text-to-speech reading, giving AI voice systems clear guidance on what to verbalize. Minor implementation effort with meaningful improvement in voice contexts.

Conclusion

Voice and AI assistant recommendations operate on the same fundamental currency as all AI visibility: entity clarity, review quality, and authoritative structured data. The difference is the zero-tolerance nature of voice recommendation selection — the assistant names one business, and all the others are invisible for that interaction. Building toward voice recommendation presence means closing every foundation gap and reaching for the review quality that makes your business the confident choice when an assistant must name just one.